

The Sūtra Called 'The Three Dharmas'

Tridharmanāma Sūtra · Toh 253 · Derge Kangyur

ཆསོ་གསུམ་པ་ནས་བརྒྱུད་མེད།

Toh 253 in the Kangyur is a brief Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Tri-dharma-nāma-sūtra and in Tibetan as Chos gsum pa zhes bya ba'i mdo, meaning "The Sūtra Called 'The Three Dharmas.'" It belongs to the general class of sūtra literature and records a teaching delivered by the Buddha at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove, addressed to an assembly of monks. The discourse identifies three qualities — attachment, miserliness, and heedlessness — that obstruct foolish persons from giving gifts, making merit, and maintaining moral discipline, and it contrasts these with the three corresponding virtues that enable practitioners to flourish in the Dharma. The text appears in the Kangyur as part of a sequence of short Mahāyāna sūtras and is notable for its concise, practical focus on the ethical foundations of Buddhist practice.

The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called "The Accomplishing Fourth" is complete.

In the Indian language: Tri-dharma-nāma-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra Called "The Three Dharmas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of monks. Then the Blessed One addressed the monks:

"Monks, there are here certain foolish persons who, if endowed with three things that are contrary to the noble Dharma, do not give gifts, do not make merit, and do not undertake and abide in proper moral discipline. What are the three? They are as follows: attachment, miserliness, and heedlessness. Monks, because such foolish persons here are endowed with these three things contrary to the noble Dharma — because they have not given gifts, have not made merit, and have not undertaken and abided in proper moral discipline — when this body breaks apart and they die, they will be born in the lower realms, the bad destinations, the fallen states: among the beings of hell. Monks, a noble person endowed with three noble Dharmas gives gifts, makes merit, and undertakes and abides in proper moral discipline. What are the three? They are as follows: non-attachment, freedom from miserliness, and heedfulness. Monks, when a noble person is endowed with these three noble

Dharmas — having given gifts, made merit, and having undertaken and abided in proper moral discipline — when this body breaks apart and they die, they will be born in a happy destination, in the heavenly world, among the gods."

The Blessed One spoke these words, and having so spoken, the Sugata, the Well-Gone One, the Teacher further declared:

Because through miserliness and heedlessness
one does not give gifts,
therefore the wise person who desires merit
should give generously.

The fear that the miser holds
is this very hunger and thirst;
that very fear through which one does not give here
becomes the fear of humankind itself.

Whoever, through the power of miserliness,
fears to give away what they have —
in this world and in the world beyond,
that one will be divided from the childlike multitude.

But those who, having abandoned miserliness,
give at the proper time —
even though they die, they have not truly died,
like a traveler of fine repute.

Those for whom it is very hard to give,
whether little or much —
those who give what is hard to give
perform a difficult deed.

The ignoble do not understand this;
they do not transgress against the noble Dharma.
Therefore the noble and the ignoble differ,
and when they depart from this life,
the ignoble go to hell
while the noble go to the higher realms.

One oppressed by old age has no refuge;
when life is short, the time when breath is taken draws near.
Those who see this fear of death
should rightly engage in merit and happiness.

Whatever livelihood one sustains here, having abandoned women and attached to this,
even if through hardship one gives but a little —
a thousand grand sacrificial offerings of a thousand each
cannot equal even one sixteenth part of that.

Why is it that lavish and grand sacrificial offerings
do not travel the path proper to sacrifice?
And how is it that even the great among a thousand sacrificial thousands
cannot amount to one sixteenth part of that?

Some childish ones here kill and bind others,
and take what is not given — the wealth of others — and come to ruin.
The fee of such a patron, given with a tearful face, under compulsion,
does not travel the path proper to sacrifice.

Thus those lavish and grand sacrificial offerings
do not travel the path proper to sacrifice,
and thus even a thousand of those thousand sacrifices
cannot equal one sixteenth part of that.

Those who are not slothful —

those who are not slothful, who give away wealth acquired through righteous
means — and who give what is difficult to give — by their own merit they go to
the abode of the gods.

Thus did the Blessed One declare, and those monks rejoiced and praised the
words of the Blessed One.

The Sūtra Called "The Third Dharma" is complete.

Translated by the Indian preceptor Jinamitra and the great translator-monk
Devaśāndra, and edited and established by the translator Paltsek.

Translator's Notes

- The passage begins with a colophon closing a prior text ("The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called 'The Accomplishing Fourth' is complete") and then opens the new sūtra, the Tri-dharma-sūtra. The Tibetan title "chos gsum pa" could also be rendered "The Sūtra of the Three Dharmas," which is the rendering used here.

The verse section toward the end contains the classical Indian comparison of pure, voluntary small gifts to the sixteen-fold superiority over large sacrifices performed through coercion or impure livelihood — a standard teaching also found in Pāli parallels (AN 3.57 and related passages). The "sixteenth part" idiom reflects the Indian mathematical idiom for an

incomparably smaller fraction.

The final line "Those who are not slothful —" is incomplete in the source text as provided; the passage breaks off mid-verse.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.